

CHINATOWN

by

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FULL SCREEN PHOTOGRAPH

Grainy but unmistakably a man and woman making love. Photograph shakes. SOUND of a man MOANING in anguish. The photograph is dropped, REVEALING ANOTHER, MORE compromising one. Then another, and another. More moans.

CURLY'S VOICE
(crying out)

Oh, no.

INT. GITTES' OFFICE

CURLY drops the photos on Gittes' desk. Curly towers over GITTES and sweats heavily through his workman's clothes, his breathing progressively more labored. A drop plunks on Gittes' shiny desk top.

Gittes notes it. A fan whiffs overhead. Gittes glances up at it. He looks cool and brisk in a white linen suit despite the heat. Never taking his eyes off Curly, he lights a cigarette using a lighter with a "nail" on his desk.

Curly, with another anguished sob, turns and rams his fist into the wall, kicking the wastebasket as he does. He starts to sob again, slides along the wall where his fist has left a noticeable dent and its impact has sent the signed photos of several movie stars askew.

Curly slides on into the blinds and sinks to his knees. He is weeping heavily now, and is in such pain that he actually bites into the blinds.

Gittes doesn't move from his chair.

GITTES
All right, enough is enough. You can't eat
the Venetian blinds, Curly. I just had 'em
installed on Wednesday.

Curly responds slowly, rising to his feet, crying. Gittes reaches into his desk and pulls out a shot glass, quickly selects a cheaper bottle of bourbon from several fifths of more expensive whiskeys.

Gittes pours a large shot. He shoves the glass across his desk toward Curly.

GITTES
Down the hatch.

Curly stares dumbly at it. Then picks it up, and drains it. He sinks back into the chair opposite Gittes, begins to cry quietly.

CURLY
(drinking, relaxing a
little)
She's just no good.

GITTES
What can I tell you, Kid? You're right. When
you're right, you're right, and you're right.

CURLY
Ain't worth thinking about.

Gittes leaves the bottle with Curly.

GITTES
You're absolutely right, I wouldn't give her
another thought.

CURLY
(pouring himself)
You know, you're okay, Mr. Gittes. I know
it's your job, but you're okay.

GITTES
(settling back, breathing
a little easier)
Thanks, Curly. Call me Jake.

CURLY
Thanks. You know something, Jake?

GITTES
What's that, Curly?

CURLY
I think I'll kill her.

INT. DUFFY & WALSH'S OFFICE

Noticeably less plush than Gittes's. A well-groomed, dark-haired
WOMAN sits nervously between their two desks, fiddling with the veil
on her pillbox hat.

WOMAN
I was hoping Mr. Gittes could see to this
personally.

WALSH
(almost the manner of
someone comforting the
bereaved)
If you'll allow us to complete our
preliminary questioning, by then he'll be
free.

There is the SOUND of ANOTHER MOAN coming from Gittes' Office.
Something made of glass shatters. The Woman grows more edgy.

INT. GITTES' OFFICE - GITTES & CURLY

Gittes and Curly stand in front of the desk, Gittes staring
contemptuously at the heavy breathing hulk towering over him. Gittes
takes a handkerchief and wipes away the plunk of perspiration on his
desk.

CURLY
(crying)
They don't kill a guy for that.

GITTES
Oh they don't?

CURLY
Not for your wife. That's the unwritten law.

Gittes pounds the photos on the desk, shouting;

GITTES
I'll tell you the unwritten law, you dumb son
of a bitch, you gotta be rich to kill
somebody, anybody and get away with it. You
think you got that kind of dough, you think
you got that kind of class?

Curly shrinks back a little.

CURLY
... No...

GITTES
You bet your ass you don't. You can't even
pay me off.

This seems to upset Curly even more.

CURLY
I'll pay the rest next trip. We only caught
sixty ton of skipjack around San Benedict. We
hit a chubasco, they don't pay you for
skipjack the way they do for tuna or
albacore.

GITTES
(easing him out of his
office)
Forget it. I only mention it to illustrate a
point...

INT. OFFICE RECEPTION

He's now walking him past SOPHIE who pointedly averts her gaze. He
opens the door where on the pebbled glass can be read: "J. J. GITTES
and Associates. DISCREET INVESTIGATION"

GITTES
I don't want your last dime.

He throws an arm around Curly and flashes a dazzling smile.

GITTES
(continuing)
What kind of guy do you think I am?

CURLY
Thanks, Mr. Gittes.

GITTES

Call me Jake. Careful driving home, Curly.

He shuts the door on him and the smile disappears.

He shakes his head, starting to swear under his breath.

SOPHIE

A Mrs. Mulwray is waiting for you, with Mr. Walsh and Mr. Duffy.

Gittes nods, walks on in.

INT. DUFFY AND WALSH'S OFFICE

Walsh rises when Gittes enters.

WALSH

Mrs. Mulwray, may I present Mr. Gittes?

Gittes walks over to her and again flashes a warm, sympathetic smile.

GITTES

How do you do, Mrs. Mulwray?

MRS. MULWRAY

Mr. Gittes...

GITTES

Now, Mrs. Mulwray, what seems to be the problem?

She holds her breath. The revelation isn't easy for her.

MRS. MULWRAY

My husband, I believe, is seeing another woman.

Gittes looks mildly shocked. He turns for confirmation to his two partners.

GITTES

(gravely)

No, really?

MRS. MULWRAY

I'm afraid so.

GITTES

I am sorry.

Gittes pulls up a chair sitting next to Mrs. Mulwray between Duffy and Walsh. Duffy cracks his gum.

Gittes gives him an irritated glance. Duffy stops chewing.

MRS. MULWRAY

Can't we talk about this alone, Mr. Gittes?

GITTES

I'm afraid not, Mrs. Mulwray. These men are my operatives and at some point they're going to assist me. I can't do everything myself.

MRS. MULWRAY

Of course not.

GITTES

Now, what makes you certain he is involved with someone?

Mrs. Mulwray hesitates. She seems uncommonly nervous at the question.

MRS. MULWRAY

A wife can tell.

Gittes sighs.

GITTES

Mrs. Mulwray, do you love your husband?

MRS. MULWRAY

(shocked)

... Yes of course.

GITTES

(deliberately)

Then go home and forget about it.

MRS. MULWRAY

But...

GITTES

(staring intently at her)

I'm sure he loves you, too. You know the expression, let sleeping dogs lie? You're better off not knowing.

MRS. MULWRAY

(with some real anxiety)

But I have to know.

Her intensity is genuine. Gittes looks to his two partners.

GITTES

All right, what's your husband's first name?

MRS. MULWRAY

Hollis. Hollis Mulwray.

GITTES

(visibly surprised)

Water and Power?

Mrs. Mulwray nods, almost shyly. Gittes is now casually but carefully checking out the detailing of Mrs. Mulwray's dress - her handbag, shoes, etc.

MRS. MULWRAY
He's the Chief Engineer.

DUFFY
(a little eagerly)
Chief Engineer?

Gittes' glance tells Duffy Gittes wants to do the questioning. Mrs. Mulwray nods.

GITTES
(confidentially)
This type of investigation can be hard on
your pocketbook, Mrs. Mulwray. It takes time.

MRS. MULWRAY
Money doesn't matter to me, Mr. Gittes.

Gittes sighs.

GITTES
Very well. We'll see what we can do.

EXT. CITY HALL - MORNING

Already shimmering with heat.

A drunk blows his nose with his fingers into the fountain at the foot of the steps.
Gittes, impeccably dressed, passes the drunk on the way up the stairs.

INT. COUNCIL CHAMBERS

Former Mayor SAM BAGBY is speaking. Behind him is a huge map, with overleafs and bold lettering:

"PROPOSED ALTO VALLEJO DAM AND RESERVOIR"

Some of the councilmen are reading funny papers and gossip columns while Bagby is speaking.

BAGBY
Gentlemen, today you can walk out that door,
turn right, hop on a streetcar and in twenty-
five minutes end up smack in the Pacific
Ocean. Now you can swim in it, you can fish
in it, you can sail in it but you can't drink
it, you can't water your lawns with it, you
can't irrigate an orange grove with it.
Remember we live next door to the ocean but
we also live on the edge of the desert. Los
Angeles is a desert community. Beneath this
building, beneath every street there's a
desert. Without water the dust will rise up
and cover us as though we'd never existed!
(pausing, letting the
implication sink in)